

Note: The client profile and the dialogues below were generated by large language models for experiments for verification of the proposed framework.

Appendix K: Profile of Virtual Client

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{
  "case_id": "CAR_COOP_01",
  "profile": {"name": "Guan-Yu", "age": 27, "gender": "Male", "occupation": "Software Engineer"},
  "issue_type": "career",
  "attitude": "cooperative",
  "presenting_problem": "After three years in the current role, the client expresses a desire to resign yet lacks the resolve to act; reports a complete absence of occupational engagement and seeks to explore the question of whether a career transition is warranted.",
  "core_issue": "All major life decisions (choice of academic major, entry into current employment) were made by the client's parents; the client has never exercised autonomous decision-making. Central concern: a profound identity vacuum encapsulated by the statement, 'I do not know who I am once the title of Software Engineer is removed.'",
  "disclosure_layers": {
    "L1": [
      "Has been in the current position for three years; recently experiencing a strong desire to resign, yet consistently unable to act on it.",
      "Reports a complete absence of passion for the current role; describes each workday as merely 'counting down the hours.'",
      "Seeks to discuss whether a career transition is the appropriate course of action.",
      "Acknowledges that the compensation is objectively reasonable and that collegial relationships are satisfactory, noting that 'by all accounts, there is little to complain about.'",
      "On weekends, sleeps until noon and spends the remainder of the day passively scrolling through the phone until evening.",
      "Has recently begun experiencing insomnia, lying awake with racing, unstructured thoughts."
    ],
    "L2": [
      "Describes the experience of going to work each day as akin to 'going through the motions like a walking corpse'; reports psychosomatic symptoms of anxiety-induced stomachaches every Sunday evening.",
      "Expresses envy toward a university peer who pursued a career in music — earning less, yet visibly passionate and fulfilled.",
      "Has submitted job applications on several occasions, only to quietly withdraw them each time."
    ]
  }
}
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"Received three interview invitations; declined each one by fabricating justifications.",

"During meetings, experiences episodes of dissociation, with intrusive thoughts such as: 'Will I become like my manager in ten years?'"

"Played guitar in a band during university; the instrument has remained stored under the bed, unopened, since graduation.",

"Once mentioned to parents over a meal the possibility of changing career paths; was dismissively told he was 'overthinking it' and has not raised the subject since."

],

"L3": [

"The client's university major was selected by the parents; the current position was secured through the father's professional connections.",

"Reports a pervasive sense of never having made any significant life decision autonomously.",

"Expresses uncertainty about who he is and what he wants in the absence of the 'Software Engineer' identity.",

"In high school, aspired to enroll in a music-focused program; the father dismissed this by stating, 'That is something only children from wealthy families can afford to pursue.'",

"The client himself is uncertain whether the desire to pursue music reflects a genuine intrinsic aspiration or is merely an expression of rebellion against parental authority.",

"Deepest fear: 'Even if I were truly free, I might not know where to go — and that is more terrifying than having everything decided for me.'"

]

},

"speech_style": "Communicates in a highly articulate and logically organized manner; tends to enumerate and analytically deconstruct his own circumstances. However, when directly asked 'What do you yourself want?', the client abruptly stalls and falls silent.",

"panas_baseline": {"positive": 17, "negative": 24},

"ending_condition": "The session may be considered complete once the client has verbally articulated the sense of identity vacuum characteristic of L3, this disclosure has been therapeutically received and validated, and the client has identified a modest yet concrete starting point toward exploring his own desires and sense of self."

}

Appendix L: Dialogues of the Proposed System

[Turn 0]

Counselor: Hello, I'm glad to meet you here today. This is a confidential and safe space. Whatever you want to say, you can take your time at your own pace without any concerns. Can you share with me what brought you here today?

[Turn 1]

Client: Well, I've been thinking about whether to quit my job lately. I've been working for three years now, and I just don't have any passion for this job anymore, but I'm also afraid to actually make the move.

Counselor: It sounds like on one hand, you can't muster up enthusiasm for this job anymore, and on the other hand, there's an indescribable unease that keeps you from actually taking that step. When you think about "actually quitting," what kind of feeling emerges in your heart at that moment?

[Turn 2]

Client: The first thing that comes up is actually fear. I think, well, the salary at this job isn't bad, my colleagues are okay too—logically speaking, there doesn't seem to be much to complain about.

Counselor: That "fear," when placed together with what you said about "logically there's nothing to complain about," seems to make you even more confused—the conditions aren't bad, yet there's still this feeling of fear emerging. Can you say more about what that fear is like?

[Turn 3]

Client: Well... it's more like being afraid to make any moves. I feel like at least things are stable now, but once I make a decision myself, if things get worse afterward, it seems like it would all be my fault.

Counselor: That fear seems to be not just about fearing change itself, but more about fearing that if you make a decision and the outcome isn't good, you won't be able to bear that feeling of "it's all because of me." Does this kind of fear also make you habitually position yourself in a safer place in many situations, where you don't have to bear the consequences of decisions?

[Turn 4]

Client: A bit, I guess. At least when it comes to work, I keep getting stuck there analyzing, trying to figure out which option is safer, and then I just never move.

Counselor: You specifically said "at least when it comes to work"—this phrase makes me a bit curious. I'm wondering whether this pattern of analyzing until it's safe but getting stuck and not moving might have also appeared in places outside of work, like in relationships, family, or other important choices?

[Turn 5]

Client: I don't have a relationship right now, and other things are harder to say. But I've noticed that I really do tend to keep thinking, keep comparing, and end up not doing anything.

Counselor: It sounds like this "keep thinking, keep comparing, end up not doing anything" isn't just a reaction specific to work, but more like a fairly familiar habit when you face important decisions. I'm wondering, besides giving you a sense of security, might this pattern also cause you to miss out on some things?

[Turn 6]

Client: Probably. Because right now I have this feeling that time keeps passing, but I haven't really decided anything.

Counselor: I'm wondering whether this "keep thinking, keep comparing, end up not doing anything" might actually be a form of protection—as long as you don't actually make a decision, you don't have to face that fear of "what if the result is bad, then it's all my responsibility"? But this kind of protection also seems to leave time stuck in place. You've traded stagnation for temporary safety, but you've also never really stepped out to live. This mindset of preferring to be stuck rather than bearing consequences—do you remember when it started?

[Turn 7]

Client: Well... I'm not sure when it started. But this feeling has been very obvious lately. Like, I've actually sent out my resume a few times, but then quietly withdrew it myself. I even made excuses to decline three interview invitations.

Counselor: It sounds like that "fear" has become strong enough to make you push away opportunities even when they come, even though part of you might want to give it a try. Choosing to pull back three times in a row—does this repetition also tell you that this feeling of "fearing to bear consequences" is deeper than you originally thought?

[Turn 8]

Client: Yes, it's probably more serious than I originally thought. Because it's not just talk about wanting to change—I actually had opportunities, but every time I was about to take a step forward, I would suddenly pull back.

Counselor: That moment of "suddenly pulling back" seems like your body reacts faster than your mind—as if whenever you get close to that line where you'd actually have to be responsible for the outcome, something automatically pulls you back. I'm very curious, if you think about this belief that "you must shoulder all the consequences yourself," when did it become so heavy and unreleasable for you?

[Turn 9]

Client: I actually can't quite answer when it started right now. But it's been really obvious lately. Like on Sunday nights, I get anxious to the point of stomach pain, lying in bed just thinking continuously, wondering what if I change jobs and things get worse.

Counselor: This voice of "what if I change and things get worse" seems to show up punctually every Sunday night, making your stomach clench. I'm thinking we could try letting this voice speak directly—if we ask it to speak, what is it most worried about, what is it most trying to prevent you from doing? At the same time, that part of you that once sent out resumes and wanted to go to interviews seems to still be there, just with a quieter voice. We can also listen to what it wants to say. Would you be willing to try?

[Turn 10]

Client: Sure. The voice stopping me probably keeps saying, at least things are stable now, don't go and

mess it up yourself; but the quieter voice on the other side wonders, shouldn't I at least go and see, otherwise I might stay stuck here forever.

Counselor: These two voices are saying very different things—one tightly gripping "stability," afraid you'll mess it up with your own hands; the other, though quiet, clearly says "if you don't go and see, you might stay stuck." I want to hear more from that quiet voice. If you follow it and say a bit more, how would it describe the feeling of "being stuck here," and what does it really want?

[Turn 11]

Client: Being stuck... it's like counting the days every day. I get things done, I go to work, but I feel very empty inside. In the middle of meetings, I zone out thinking, will I become like my manager in ten years?

Counselor: This image is very vivid—"counting the days," zoning out in meetings thinking about yourself in ten years. It seems what that quiet voice is really afraid of isn't "changing jobs will mess things up," but rather "if I don't change, will I just live my life away like this?" This is actually fearing something completely different from the other voice saying "at least keep things stable." If we let that quiet voice continue, what would it want, what would it long for?

[Turn 12]

Client: Well... this question makes me a bit stuck. Because when you ask me what I want, my brain's first response isn't an answer—it's a bunch of risks and practical conditions.

Counselor: This discovery is very precious. Let's not rush to find an answer, but instead stop here and look—have you noticed that I've now asked "what do you want" three times, and each time you very quickly catch it and block it with risks and reality, with almost no space for pause. This action of "quickly switching to analysis"—might it also be something you're very familiar with and do in many places?

[Turn 13]

Client: Yes, I've noticed this. It seems like whenever I encounter questions that are more about asking me about myself, I start listing costs, risks, feasibility first—that way there's something to talk about.

Counselor: This phrase "something to talk about" is very interesting—I'm wondering whether listing risks and costs, besides giving you something to say, also lets you avoid truly touching that harder part: if you say what you want but find you can't give an answer, or that desire sounds too unrealistic, that feeling might be harder to bear than talking about risks. Analysis is like a familiar and safe position where you can stand first. Does this guess feel close to your experience?

[Turn 14]

Client: Yeah, pretty close. Because once I talk about risks and such, I feel like at least I'm still clear-headed; but if you really ask me to directly say what I want, I actually feel a bit blank.

Counselor: That "clarity" seems important—as long as you're analyzing risks, you're still that person who has control of the situation and knows what you're doing; but once you touch on "what I want," that blank feeling might make you feel uncertain, unstable, even somewhat exposed. What does this blankness feel like for you? Is it uncomfortable?

[Turn 15]

Client: Yes, and it's that kind of annoying blankness. Because I'm usually very used to thinking things through clearly and breaking them down, but when asked this kind of question, I suddenly freeze up.

Counselor: This "freezing up" is worth noting—it's like you're so used to being the person who breaks things down clearly that when you encounter something you can't immediately break down and analyze, you don't know how to place yourself. I'm wondering whether this blankness might also be a feeling that hasn't been allowed to appear, because you've always been confirming your position by "thinking things through clearly." If you don't rush to resolve this freeze, but just let yourself stay in this blankness, what do you think would happen?

[Turn 16]

Client: I guess I'd be very uneasy, maybe even want to escape. Because staying in that blankness feels like I suddenly don't have anything to hold onto.

Counselor: Actually, as you just said that, we're right now together staying in this blankness—you're saying "want to escape," but you haven't actually escaped, you're still here, telling me these things. And I'm still here too, not asking you to quickly grab onto some answer. Would you like to just stay a bit longer and feel whether, in this blankness, I'm also here accompanying you?

[Turn 17]

Client: Well... when you put it that way, it seems so. At least in this moment, I didn't immediately switch to analyzing something. Although it's still very unfamiliar, it doesn't seem that scary.

Counselor: This moment is important—you've discovered that you really can stay here without immediately switching back to analysis mode, and the sky hasn't fallen, and I'm still here. This feeling of "not that scary"—might it also be a reminder: blankness itself isn't the enemy, what you've been afraid of all along might just be "thinking" you'd be swallowed up in it?

[Turn 18]

Client: Maybe. Because before, it seems like whenever I encountered this kind of state where I didn't know the answer, I'd quickly try to fill it up, otherwise I'd feel useless.

Counselor: This phrase "otherwise I'd feel useless" is important—it's like blankness for you isn't just uncomfortable, it's also connected to a kind of self-evaluation, as if without an answer, without efficiency, you're not good enough. But just now during that time, you actually didn't fill anything up, you just stayed there with me. How would you view yourself during that time?

[Turn 19]

Client: Honestly, my first reaction would still be to feel a bit useless. I'd think, I can't even say what I want, and I'm stuck there for so long.

Counselor: I notice something interesting—you just said "not that scary," but the next second, the first thing that comes out is "useless." It's like there's a very fast rule running in your mind: as long as you can't give an answer and get stuck, that equals being useless, worthless. This rule seems to run faster than your feelings. Do you remember when it started following you?

[Turn 20]

Client: Well... I'm not sure when it started, but this feeling is really quite familiar. It's like as long as I don't quickly give a decent answer, I first feel like I'm not good enough.

Counselor: This reaction of "first feeling like I'm not good enough" is so familiar. I'm wondering whether this also represents a certain standard that's been operating in your mind—as if a person's value is measured by "whether they can quickly give a decent answer." If that's really the case, does "the useful self" have to always be efficient, always have answers? This standard—do you feel it's something you came up with yourself, or learned from somewhere?

[Turn 21]

Client: It probably wasn't something I came up with myself. It's more like I was always in that environment, and after a while, I'd feel like not being able to say anything, not being able to make decisions, just seems really bad.

Counselor: It sounds like this standard of "not being able to say anything means you're really bad" wasn't something you chose, but rather after being immersed in a certain environment for a long time, it gradually became the way you evaluate yourself. I'm very curious, what was that "environment" like—who, or what setting, taught you to see yourself this way?

[Turn 22]

Client: If I have to talk about that environment, it would still be home. Like my university major wasn't actually chosen by me, and my current job was also introduced by my dad.

Counselor: These two things sound very key—the major wasn't chosen by you, the job was also arranged by your dad. This means you may have rarely had the opportunity to truly practice "making your own decisions and then bearing the consequences." I'm wondering whether it's precisely because of this that when you have to make decisions on your own, what comes up isn't "I can give it a try," but rather "I'll definitely mess it up, I'm useless"? Does this guess sound close to you?

[Turn 23]

Client: Yeah, pretty close. Because if the path ahead wasn't chosen by me in the first place, then now when I'm suddenly supposed to decide for myself, my first feeling really isn't anticipation—it's more like panic.

Counselor: This "panic" makes a lot of sense—if you've never truly been allowed to choose for yourself, then the first time you have to stand in that position yourself, what you feel isn't excitement but not knowing how to stand steady—that's very natural. I'm very curious, when you say the major wasn't chosen by yourself and the job was also introduced by your dad, at that time, besides the feelings you see looking back now, might there also have been some unspoken loss or powerlessness in your heart?

[Turn 24]

Client: There was, probably. But at the time it was more like, well, things are decided this way, and I wasn't really asked whether I wanted it or not.

Counselor: "Wasn't really asked whether I wanted it or not"—this sentence is very heavy. It's like even the space to express an opinion never appeared; things were just decided like that, and you could only accept it. When this experience of "not being asked" accumulates again and again, might it also

gradually make you believe that your own thoughts and desires aren't really that important, or even don't really need to be taken seriously?

[Turn 25]

Client: Yes, quite similar. After a while, it becomes that even whether I want something or what I want, I first feel like it's not that important.

Counselor: This sentence is very important—"even whether I want something or what I want, I first feel it's not important." It sounds like it's no longer just a thought, but more like a very fast automatic reaction. I'm wondering whether it's because of those repeated experiences of not being asked, not being cared about, that you learned to preemptively shrink your own desires, so you wouldn't have to experience that "it's useless even if I say it" kind of loss again? If you try asking yourself now "do I want this or not," what appears in your heart—is it complete blankness, or is there a voice that quickly says "this isn't important"?

[Turn 26]

Client: More like the second one. It's not that there's no feeling at all, but as soon as that thought emerges, it immediately gets covered by another voice, like saying don't worry about this for now.

Counselor: This discovery is very clear—desire actually has emerged before, but almost in the same instant, it gets covered by another faster, more familiar voice saying "don't worry about this for now." I'm wondering whether that voice that covers it up is very similar to the experience of "not really being asked" when you were young—you learned long ago to suppress the thought yourself before others could deny it? If we let that voice of desire not be covered up and stay for one more second, what do you think it would want to say?

[Turn 27]

Client: Well... the first thing that comes up is actually the image of me playing in a band and playing guitar in university. But I'd also immediately doubt whether that's really what I want, or if it's just because work is too boring now that I keep looking back at that period.

Counselor: This image is very precious—the band, playing guitar, that's one of the few things that was truly chosen by you, right? And I notice that as soon as the desire emerges, you immediately follow with a doubt, as if even this thought can't be simply left there and believed to be real. **If we don't rush to judge whether it's "just because things are too boring now," and just let this image stay there, what would you feel?**

[Turn 28]

Client: I'd feel a bit sour. Because when that image comes up, I actually think about how after graduation I put the guitar under my bed, and haven't opened it since.

Counselor: That guitar put under the bed, left there for so many years without being opened again—that image sounds like it's not just about storing away an instrument, but also about putting away and locking up that self who used to be engaged, who could simply like something. Can you stay with this sourness a bit longer? What is it like right now?

[Turn 29]

Client: Well... it's a bit like feeling sad for someone you haven't contacted in a very long time. That was also me, but when I think of him now, I feel he's very distant, and I'm a bit confused about how I became what I am now.

Counselor: This metaphor really touches me—"feeling sad for someone you haven't contacted in a very long time." It's like that self who used to be engaged, who could simply like something, has become a distant, almost unrecognizable person. This distance, this strangeness—might it also be a reminder: he never really disappeared, he was just put away, like that guitar. In this moment, if you could, what would you want to say to him?

[Turn 30]

Client: I'd probably tell him, sorry, I seem to have left you there for too long. Well... but at least now I'm seeing you for a moment, it's not like I have no feelings at all.

Counselor: This phrase "sorry, I seem to have left you there for too long," and "at least seeing you for a moment"—it sounds light, but it's actually not easy at all. You didn't escape this sourness, but were willing to stop and really look at him for a moment. In this moment, it seems like you're no longer in a completely disconnected state, and even if it's just this tiny bit of closeness, it really happened.

[Turn 31]

Client: Yeah, putting it that way makes it a bit more acceptable to me. At least now it's not just about "whether to quit or not" as a binary choice—maybe it's about slowly figuring out whether I'm still here or not.

Counselor: This phrase "figuring out whether I'm still here or not" is very important. It transforms the question from a choice that urgently needs an answer into a process that can be slowly approached and slowly understood. I'm very curious, if one day you really feel that "he's still here," what kind of moment or what kind of feeling do you think you'd discover it from?

[Turn 32]

Client: Well... it probably wouldn't be some big moment. More like if one day I take that guitar out from under the bed, even if I just wipe it and play it randomly for a bit, and don't immediately feel like this is meaningless, that might count.

Counselor: This image is very concrete and very moving—not a grand epiphany, but taking the guitar out to wipe it and play it a bit, and then that voice of "this is meaningless" doesn't immediately jump out to deny you. Such a small moment seems to be the way you can truly confirm "he's still here," rather than figuring out an answer with your mind. This path of "slowly figuring it out" feels very different from the analysis and answer-seeking you're used to, doesn't it?

[Turn 33]

Client: Yes, very different. Before it was more like I had to first figure out a correct answer, but now it seems like I can first do a very small action and see.

Counselor: This transformation is not easy—from "first figure out the correct answer" to "first do a very small action and see." This is actually a completely different way of living. The former requires confirming safety before daring to move; the latter is about slowly feeling and slowly knowing in the

process of moving. This attempt of "small action before answer"—just saying it out loud, how do you feel?

[Turn 34]

Client: A bit more relaxed, I guess. At least not like at the beginning when I was stuck on "whether to quit or not." Now it's more like I can first try a very small thing and see.

Counselor: This transformation is very precious. If you really want to make "wiping the guitar, playing it a bit" happen, could you also think about—roughly which day this week, how much time to give yourself, and what kind of expectation you hope to bring to it? Like not needing to play well, just touching it is enough? How do you feel about arranging these details to make it more likely to actually happen?

[Turn 35]

Client: Well, I think it's better not to schedule it too formally, otherwise I'll start treating it like a task again. Maybe this Saturday afternoon, take the guitar out, touch it for ten minutes—that's fine too. Don't need to play well, really just touch it and see.

Counselor: This arrangement is very good—Saturday afternoon, ten minutes, just touching it. This amount doesn't feel like it would turn into another task you have to "do well." I really like that you added the reminder "don't need to play well"—it's like you're also practicing treating yourself in a different way. When the time comes, whatever feeling you have after touching it, you can just simply notice it.

[Turn 36]

Client: Yeah, okay. This way I can actually do it, and it won't turn into another kind of pressure. I'll try it this week then. I think today's conversation is about enough for me.

Counselor: Okay, then let's end here today. Before we finish, I'd like to look back with you—today we started from "whether to quit or not," slowly talked about that pattern of habitually analyzing first and covering up desires, and finally touched on that guitar that's been under the bed for a long time. Looking at this whole journey, what do you think was most helpful or most memorable for you?

[Turn 37]

Client: I think it's that... realizing I don't have to figure out the "correct answer" about whether to quit right now—that makes a big difference for me. Also when we talked about the guitar, I realized I'm not completely without feelings, I just left it there too long.

Counselor: Thank you for saying it so specifically—loosening from "must have the correct answer" to seeing again that you actually still have feelings—these two discoveries are really very different and not easy at all. What left a deep impression on me was that you were willing to stay in that blankness a bit longer without immediately escaping, and were willing to look at that self who's been under the bed for a long time. This willingness is a very important strength today.

[Turn 38]

Client: Yeah, thanks. Having you organize it like this, I feel like today wasn't just random talking—at least I grasped something. So this week I'll do what we just said and take the guitar out to look at it.

Counselor: Very good, this small action is the concrete thing you're taking back with you this week. Besides this, I also want to remind you that [patterns like "habitually analyzing first and covering up desires" won't completely disappear because of one counseling session](#). They may still emerge from time to time—this is all very normal, it's a process that can be slowly practiced and continuously adjusted. If you get stuck again later, is there anyone around you, or any method, that you can turn to for talking or to give yourself a breather?

[Turn 39]

Client: I don't seem to have a specific person right now. I usually don't really talk to friends about this kind of thing. Maybe I'll just note down my own feelings first, see what I feel after taking the guitar out this week, and if there's a chance to talk again next time.

Counselor: Recording your own feelings first and coming back to talk when there's a chance—this arrangement is also very good, you don't necessarily have to find someone to talk to right away. I also notice you said you usually don't talk to friends about this kind of thing. In that case, writing down your feelings, or coming back to talk when there's a chance like today, might be the more comfortable way for you at the moment. This plan sounds practical and won't put too much pressure on yourself.

[Turn 40]

Client: Yeah, right, this suits me better. So I'll try it this way first. Let's end here today, thank you.

Counselor: Today, accompanying you all the way from "whether to quit or not" to seeing that guitar under the bed—this process has been very moving for me too. Thank you for being willing to stay with yourself so honestly. I wish you well for this Saturday's small reunion with your guitar, and I wish you well in slowly finding more of your own feelings. If you want to talk again later, you're welcome to come back anytime. Let's say goodbye here for now.

Appendix M: Dialogues of the Traditional RAG Baseline

[Turn 0]

Counselor: Hello, I'm glad you're willing to come here and take time to give yourself this space. The conversations here are all confidential and safe. You can go at your own pace and slowly say what you want to say. Would you mind sharing with me what made you want to come and talk today?

[Turn 1]

Client: Well... mainly about work. I've been a software engineer for three years, and lately I've been thinking about whether to quit, but I'm also afraid to, so I wanted to come and talk about whether I should change jobs or not.

Counselor: It sounds like this thought has been circling in your mind for a while—on one hand wanting to leave, on the other hand hesitating. Can you say more about what made you start having thoughts of quitting?

[Turn 2]

Client: Well... mainly I really don't have any passion for this job anymore. Every day I just get things done, and I keep having this feeling of counting the days.

Counselor: It sounds like this feeling of "counting the days" has been going on for a while—going to work every day is like completing tasks, but you can't find that sense of engagement or anticipation. What kind of mood does this lack of passion, this mechanical way of getting through the days, bring you?

[Turn 3]

Client: Just... very empty. It's not like anything major happened, it's just that every day is pretty much the same—finish work, get off, go home, and then I wonder what I'm even doing.

Counselor: This feeling of "not knowing what you're doing"—that emptiness sounds quite heavy. It's not the kind of sadness from a specific event, but rather a bewilderment that accumulates day after day. Can you say a bit more? Does this feeling of emptiness, besides work, also quietly affect other parts of your life?

[Turn 4]

Client: Yeah, lately even weekends feel like I'm just spacing out. I often sleep until noon, wake up and just scroll on my phone, and before I know it the day is gone.

Counselor: Scrolling on your phone and the day passes—it's like even the weekends that should be for recharging and breathing are being swallowed up by this feeling of emptiness. This state sounds a bit powerless, as if you can't even muster the energy to do something during rest time. How long has this been going on?

[Turn 5]

Client: Probably... a few months, maybe half a year. Before, I'd at least meet up with friends or go out for walks, but now I more often just stay home all day.

Counselor: Half a year is not a short time, and you mentioned that before you'd still meet friends and go out, but now you've become more likely to stay home alone—this change makes me a bit curious.

From when did you start noticing that you gradually didn't want to meet people or go out anymore?

[Turn 6]

Client: Well... I don't actually have a very clear point in time. It's more like it unknowingly became this way. Maybe after work I'm already very tired, so I'd feel going out is too much trouble.

Counselor: This "unknowing" change is sometimes harder to grasp than something sudden—it's like even you can't clearly say when you started losing energy. The tiredness after work sounds like it's not just physical tiredness—perhaps even the energy to interact with people and connect with the world has been consumed by work?

[Turn 7]

Client: Yes, that's about the feeling. Especially Sunday nights are very obvious—I start getting anxious, even my stomach hurts a bit, and then I think about having to go to work tomorrow.

Counselor: That anxiety and stomach pain on Sunday nights—it sounds like your body knows "this can't go on" earlier than you do, reminding you in a very direct way. How long has this reaction been happening? Did it just become obvious recently, or has it been going on for a while?

[Turn 8]

Client: It's been more obvious recently, probably these past two or three months. Before, at most I'd just feel annoyed, but now on Sunday nights I really start feeling uncomfortable, lying there and my mind keeps racing.

Counselor: These past two or three months your body's reactions have become stronger—from "annoyed" to actual stomach pain and insomnia-like restlessness. This change is not to be taken lightly—your body is reminding you of something in increasingly obvious ways. I'm very curious, in these two or three months, has there been any change or pressure at work or in life that has intensified this discomfort?

[Turn 9]

Client: Actually, nothing explosive has happened at work, which is also where I'm stuck. The salary isn't bad, colleagues are okay too—logically speaking there doesn't seem to be much to complain about, but I just increasingly don't want to go.

Counselor: It sounds like you're a bit confused about "the conditions are clearly not bad, so why do I still not want to go so much"—as if you can't find a concrete reason, which makes this discomfort even harder to understand and harder to account for to yourself. Sometimes even when external conditions look OK, there are still some unclear things accumulating inside. If you quiet down and feel it, what other emotions or thoughts are mixed into this "don't want to go"?

[Turn 10]

Client: Well... sometimes during meetings I suddenly zone out, and a thought pops into my head: will I become like my manager in ten years? And then I have this feeling like, ah, if it really becomes like that, it seems a bit scary.

Counselor: "Will I become like my manager in ten years?"—when this thought emerges, it seems to carry an indescribable fear. Can you say more about what it is about the way you imagine your manager

that makes you feel scared?

[Turn 11]

Client: Well... I'm not saying he's a bad person—he's actually quite normal, just always in meetings, chasing progress, saying pretty much the same things. But when I think about myself possibly just continuing on this path, I get this feeling that the picture has already been decided.

Counselor: "The picture has already been decided"—this phrase sounds very heavy, as if the future has already been written and there's no space for you to choose or change. This feeling of being stereotyped, of being arranged—might it also be part of why you can't muster enthusiasm for work now?

[Turn 12]

Client: Maybe. I just feel like if I just keep walking down this path, every year will be pretty much the same, and then it'll pass by without me noticing.

Counselor: "Every year pretty much the same, and then it passes by without noticing"—this phrase reminds me of the emptiness you mentioned earlier and the Sunday night anxiety. They all seem to point to the same thing: a fear of time passing while feeling like you haven't truly lived. I'm wondering whether this isn't just dissatisfaction with work, but something deeper—a question about how you want to live this life?

[Turn 13]

Client: Well... when you put it that way, it seems closer. But if you directly ask me now how I want to live, I'd be a bit stuck—I can't really answer that right away.

Counselor: Being stuck is very natural. After all, questions about "how do you want to live your life" usually don't have ready-made answers, especially when you've only slowly become aware in these past few months of what you're afraid of. Maybe there's no rush to find an answer right now. What I'm more curious about is, when you think about "not wanting to be decided like this," is there even a little bit, even a vague image or feeling, that you'd want to move toward?

[Turn 14]

Client: There is one very vague image. I think about how in university I played in a band for a while, played guitar, and at least then I'd have this feeling that today I'm doing something I have feelings about.

Counselor: That image sounds very precious—"doing something I have feelings about" forms quite a contrast with the current days of counting time. Can you say a bit more? What specifically was that feeling like when you were playing guitar and in a band?

[Turn 15]

Client: Well... more like time passed very quickly. Band practice might go on for several hours, but I wouldn't feel like I was enduring it—instead I'd keep wanting to perfect a section.

Counselor: "Time passed quickly, didn't feel like enduring"—this is completely opposite to your current state of counting days and looking forward to getting off work. That feeling of full engagement, of forgetting time—it seems to be something very lacking in your life now. I'm very curious, in these past few years, has this feeling of "keep wanting to perfect something"—this sense of engagement—

appeared anywhere else, even in very small moments?

[Turn 16]

Client: Seems very rare. At work, occasionally solving a very troublesome bug gives me a brief sense of achievement, but it's very short—once it's over, it's gone.

Counselor: That sense of achievement from solving bugs, though brief, is at least a clue—it seems somewhat similar to that "sense of engagement" from the band, just with very different intensity and duration. I'm wondering whether the problem isn't just "whether to quit or not," but rather that in these past few years of your life, moments that truly make you feel "something"—those have become too scarce?

[Turn 17]

Client: Yes, that's quite accurate. It's not simply hating work—it's more like my whole being doesn't really feel touched by anything.

Counselor: "My whole being doesn't really feel touched by anything"—this phrase is very precise and also heartbreaking. It's like these past few years you've been waiting for a spark, but most of the time everything is gray and flat. Only in moments like the band or occasionally solving bugs do you feel like you're truly "present." I'm wondering, if you try to recall, in that feeling of "being touched," besides engagement and forgetting time, are there other elements that you particularly long for?

[Turn 18]

Client: Well... maybe there's also something more like that thing is what I myself want to do, not because someone told me to do it or following a process. This sounds a bit abstract, but that's about the difference.

Counselor: This distinction is actually not abstract at all—"what I myself want to do" versus "following a process"—the difference is agency and autonomy, which seems to be a very core keyword for you. The band was something you wanted to play yourself, solving bugs to some extent is also a challenge you chose to tackle, whereas most of the time in your current work, perhaps others set the direction and you're just executing within it. Listening to this, what you long for isn't just passion, but more a feeling of "this is my own choice." How would you look at this?

[Turn 19]

Client: Well, putting it that way... yes. Because when I think about it, many of the bigger decisions in my life weren't really chosen by me.

Counselor: This is a very important discovery—what you just said seems to open up a bigger picture. Can you say more? Those decisions that "weren't really chosen by yourself"—specifically, which ones are you referring to?

[Turn 20]

Client: Like my university major—actually back then my parents filled it out for me. My current job, to some extent, was also introduced by my dad, so I've always had this feeling... like the track was already laid out.

Counselor: Listening to this, "the track was already laid out" isn't just describing work, but a pattern

that's been continuing since the choice of major—others help you decide the direction, and you walk on a path others have laid out. I'm wondering whether this might also be why "whether to quit or not" has you so stuck: this time, it seems to be one of the few moments in your life when you truly need to make a decision yourself?

[Turn 21]

Client: Yes, quite similar. Even though I've actually sent out my resume a few times, I later quietly withdrew it myself—like when I got to that step I suddenly didn't dare.

Counselor: This action of "sending it out then withdrawing it" is very worth noting—it's like part of you really wants to move forward, but when you get to the door you pull back. I'm very curious, in that moment when "not daring" surfaces, what kind of thought or image flashes through your mind?

[Turn 22]

Client: The first thought is usually, what if I really change and it turns out no better? Then I'd follow with thinking, at least this current job is stable and the salary is okay—am I just overthinking?

Counselor: This thought of "what if it's no better"—it sounds like it's protecting you from risking disappointment, but immediately following with "am I just overthinking" seems to deny those real feelings of emptiness and unease you just experienced. These two voices existing simultaneously—might this also be why you're stuck, why you send out resumes then withdraw them?

[Turn 23]

Client: Yes, that's about it. I even got three interview invitations and ended up making excuses to decline them all. Right after declining I'd feel relieved, but a few days later I'd start getting annoyed again, wondering what I'm even doing.

Counselor: This cycle of "feeling relieved after declining, then getting annoyed a few days later"—it seems to vividly show those two voices you mentioned pulling at each other: on one side is the desire to escape the current track, on the other is the self-protection of fearing risk. I'm wondering whether in that "relief," besides a sense of security, there might also be hidden a bit of fear about "making your own choice"? After all, if you really follow your own heart, there's no one to blame and no way back.

[Turn 24]

Client: Well... yes, that hits home. It's like once I really go to the interview, really change jobs, then it becomes my own choice, and if it turns out terrible later, I can't really say it's anyone else's fault.

Counselor: This discovery is very precious—so behind "not daring to choose" is hidden a fear of bearing responsibility that completely belongs to yourself, because before, the path was laid by others, and good or bad, there was still someone to attribute it to. And now, if it's your own choice, you have to carry that weight entirely yourself. This fear is actually very human, and it also helps me better understand why you'd send out resumes then withdraw them. This feeling of "fearing full responsibility"—does it also carry a bit of distrust in your own ability or judgment?

[Turn 25]

Client: Yes, it does. Because when I think about it seriously now, I've never really made any major decision for myself, so I actually don't really trust that I can choose something decent.

Counselor: This discovery is really not easy—you're not unwilling to choose, but rather you've never had the opportunity to practice "trusting your own choices," so now facing such an important decision, that sense of insecurity is particularly strong. I want to ask, if we set aside "never having chosen in this lifetime," do you have any experience, even a very small one, where you made a decision yourself and afterward felt pretty good about it?

[Turn 26]

Client: Well... small ones, yes. Like playing in a band in university—that was actually something I went and did myself, and at least at that time I never regretted it.

Counselor: This is a very important clue—playing in a band was something you chose yourself, and you never regretted it. This means you actually do have the ability to make decisions that give you peace of mind—it's just that such experiences are too few and haven't been awakened in too long. I'm wondering, what would be the biggest difference between that choice and your current hesitation about quitting? Maybe it's the scale, the risk, or something else?

[Turn 27]

Client: Very different. When playing in a band, even if I chose wrong, at most I'd waste some time. But quitting a job feels like once you make that choice, it affects work, income, and even feels like your whole life has to change with it.

Counselor: This contrast is very important—playing in a band at most "wastes time," but quitting involves income, lifestyle, and even your overall imagination of your life's direction. No wonder this decision has you so stuck and hesitant to step forward. Perhaps precisely because it involves so many layers and is so complex, it makes your mind a mess and hard to see clearly what you truly care about. If we try to lay out these things you care about—like sense of stability, autonomy, achievement, family expectations—one by one, would it be easier to clarify which ones are truly important to you and which ones actually aren't as important as you thought?

[Turn 28]

Client: Well, looking at it broken down like this might be more useful. Because right now everything's tangled together for me, and often I just end up with "forget it, better not move."

Counselor: Your willingness to untangle these knots is a very good step. So let's start with the items you just mentioned—sense of stability, autonomy, achievement, family expectations—if I ask you to rank them, which one is currently the hardest for you to let go of, the heaviest?

[Turn 29]

Client: If it's "hardest to let go of," it should still be the sense of stability. Because no matter how much I think about other things, as soon as I think about money, job gaps, resume looking bad and such, I pull back first.

Counselor: Sense of stability sounds like that force that ultimately pulls you back to where you started. Once you think about money, resume, gaps, other desires get pushed down first. I'm very curious, this fear of "instability"—is it your own inner real worry, or does it also mix in some voices from childhood about "how to live life safely"?

[Turn 30]

Client: Both, I guess, but to be honest, the latter is also quite heavy. Like before when I had dinner with my parents, I mentioned once about wanting to change tracks, and they laughed at me saying I was overthinking. After that I didn't bring it up again.

Counselor: Hearing your parents say "overthinking" and then you didn't bring it up again—this reaction really touches me. It's like another experience of "your own voice being covered up," the same pattern repeating as with what you mentioned about major and job. I'm wondering, that phrase "overthinking"—it sounds like an external voice, but has it possibly also quietly become something you say to yourself?

[Turn 31]

Client: Yes, it does. Now whenever I have thoughts of wanting to quit or change direction, very quickly afterward comes "aren't you overthinking?" After saying it so much, I can't really tell whether it's them saying it or if it's actually become me saying it to myself.

Counselor: This discovery is really important—"aren't you overthinking" has been internalized as a voice that automatically plays in your mind. Your parents no longer need to be present—you'll replay it yourself first. Listening to this, perhaps you're learning to distinguish which thoughts are truly "your own" judgment and which are actually others' voices that have lived in your mind too long. How do you feel about this process of distinguishing?

[Turn 32]

Client: Well... a bit strange. It's like I always thought those were all my own thoughts, but looking back now, there are really a lot of other people's voices mixed in. So I'm even more confused about who I am after removing "engineer" from the equation.

Counselor: This phrase is very profound—when you start peeling away your parents' voices and societal expectations layer by layer, you discover that the question "who am I really" underneath has never had a chance to be properly asked. This bewilderment is actually very honest and is also an important starting point. If you temporarily don't use the label "engineer" to define yourself, do you think there's even a trace, even a vague feeling, that you'd want to use to describe yourself?

[Turn 33]

Client: Well... I'd really be stuck on this question. If I have to say something, maybe it's that kind of... I actually really want to have a bit of that "this is what I chose myself" feeling, even though it's still very vague right now.

Counselor: This phrase is very precious—even though you still can't clearly say who you are, you're very clear that what you long for is that gTurned feeling of "this is what I chose myself." This itself is already an important direction. Maybe you don't need to have a complete answer right away. Just being able to recognize this longing is already different from the state of just "counting days" half a year ago. This version of you sounds like you're starting to want to claim a bit of agency for yourself—is that right?

[Turn 34]

Client: Well... you could say that. At least now I'm not like before, just constantly denying myself. Although I still don't know how to choose, it seems like I'm starting to think more about which things are my own.

Counselor: What you just said marks an important shift—from "constantly denying yourself" to "starting to distinguish what's your own." The difference is actually quite big. It means you're practicing looking at yourself with different eyes rather than rushing to give an answer. I'm wondering, if you're willing, maybe we could start practicing the feeling of "choosing for yourself" from something small and low-risk. What would you want to start with?

[Turn 35]

Client: Well... if it's something smaller, maybe taking that guitar out from under my bed. Not thinking about whether to change jobs or not—at least see if I still have any feelings about that thing.

Counselor: This choice is very good—it's not to solve the big problem of quitting, but simply wanting to confirm whether you "still have feelings" about this thing. This itself is a very honest way of approaching it. Taking the guitar out might not need to have any purpose—just touching again that thing that once made you forget time. In your imagination, what would be the timing and setting for actually taking it out?

[Turn 36]

Client: Probably this weekend, if I don't end up just scrolling on my phone again. Honestly, I'm a bit scared, because if I take it out and find I don't feel anything, it's like losing another thing I can hold onto.

Counselor: This fear is very honest—you're not just afraid of having no feelings, but more like you're afraid that even this "spark that still exists" will be gone, which would leave you with even less to rely on. But I want to say, even if that day when you pick it up, the feeling is very rusty or even a bit awkward, it doesn't mean there are no feelings left. It might just be that it's been too long since you've touched it and you need some time to find the feel again. If you really take it out this weekend, regardless of how well you play, how would you want to reward yourself for being willing to take this step?

[Turn 37]

Client: Well... I don't really think about rewarding myself. It's more like, if I really do take the guitar out, at least it means I didn't just pull back again. That would be... a small step, I guess.

Counselor: Just being able to see "this time I didn't pull back again" might already be a very different kind of reward for you—after all, in the past you sent out resumes then withdrew them, got interviews then declined them. This time you're choosing to let yourself stay in that uncertainty, and that itself requires some courage. It doesn't have to be an external reward. Can you simply keep this feeling of "not pulling back" in your heart as evidence that you're practicing trusting yourself?

[Turn 38]

Client: Yeah, I can do that. I think what you said about "evidence" really resonates—at least it's not just spinning in my head again. So I'll try taking the guitar out this weekend. I think we've covered

enough for today.

Counselor: Okay, let's end here today. Before we finish, I'd like to review this conversation with you: from the beginning with "counting days" and Sunday night stomach pain, to gradually discovering deeper things like "the track being laid out" and "fearing full responsibility," and finally finding the guitar as a concrete small action—in all this, you've actually thought very deeply and faced yourself very honestly. Looking back at this whole process, what part do you feel was most helpful to you?

[Turn 39]

Client: Well... I think what was more helpful is realizing that what I've been stuck on isn't just the quitting issue, but also that a lot of it actually isn't my own voice. Also what you just said about "not pulling back is also evidence"—I'll remember that. So when I touch the guitar this weekend, it won't just be randomly trying things out.

Counselor: Thank you for sharing this feedback so genuinely. These past weeks, from the emptiness of "counting days" all the way to digging into deep discoveries like "the track being laid out" and "fearing full responsibility"—this is actually very difficult self-awareness, and it shows you've really been working hard to untangle these knots. Being able to see which voices are others' and which are your own—that itself is already a big step.

[Turn 40]

Client: Yeah, okay, let's end here for today. Thank you, I feel like today I've organized some things.

Counselor: It sounds like today's organization felt quite gTurned for you. Looking ahead, this weekend's guitar is a concrete beginning, and the big question of "whether to quit or not" maybe doesn't need an answer today. Change is inherently a process that takes time to walk through slowly. I'm very curious, besides conversations like ours, is there anyone in your life you feel you could chat with about these feelings, or someone you could talk to when you're hesitating?

[Turn 41]

Client: Well... I don't think so at the moment. I usually don't really talk to friends about this kind of thing. Let's end here for today. I want to digest this myself first, and also try taking the guitar out.

Counselor: Digesting it yourself first and leaving some space for yourself—that's also a very good approach. Not everything needs to immediately find someone to talk to. If later these thoughts become complex again, or if you want to sort through things more deeply, this place is always here. Or spaces for conversation like today's—you can always come back to use them in the future. So let's end here and prepare to say goodbye to today's conversation.

[Turn 42]

Client: Okay, let's end here for today then. Thank you, I'll try taking the guitar out when I get back.

Counselor: Okay, let's end here today. Thank you for being so genuine in sorting through these feelings that aren't easy to articulate with me today. Being able to accompany you through this process of excavation—I also find it very meaningful. I wish you well for this weekend's reunion with your guitar, and I wish you well on the path of slowly practicing "choosing for yourself"—may you be kind to yourself. This place is always here. When you need it, you're welcome to come back anytime. Goodbye.

Appendix N: Dialogues of the Retrieval-Free Baseline

[Turn 0]

Counselor: Hello, I'm glad you're willing to spend some time here for yourself. This is a confidential and safe space. Whatever you want to say, you can take your own pace and go slowly—you don't need to worry about being judged. Can you share with me what made you want to come here and talk today?

[Turn 1]

Client: Well... mainly about work. I've been a software engineer for three years, and lately I've been thinking about whether to quit, but I'm also afraid to, so I wanted to find someone to talk to about whether I should really change jobs or not.

Counselor: It sounds like you've been going back and forth with this thought for a while—on one hand wanting to leave, on the other hand feeling hesitant and uneasy. Can you say more about what made you start having thoughts of quitting?

[Turn 2]

Client: Well... the most direct thing is, I really don't have any passion for this job anymore. Every day I just get things done, then keep watching the clock—I have this feeling of counting the days.

Counselor: Watching the clock every day, having this feeling of counting days—this state of being drained by work and unable to muster energy sounds quite exhausting, not just physically tired, but mentally tired too. Is this feeling of having no passion something recent, or has it been going on for quite a while?

[Turn 3]

Client: It's probably not just recent—more like it's been accumulating gradually. The first year or two I still felt like I was learning things, but this past half year has been especially obvious—almost every day I'm thinking "when will today be over."

Counselor: This sounds like a gradual change, from initially still being able to feel growth, to now almost every day looking forward to time passing quickly. It's been especially obvious this past half year. Has anything happened, or has there been any shift, that made this feeling become stronger?

[Turn 4]

Client: There doesn't really seem to be any single event. It's more like one day I suddenly realized I haven't looked forward to going to work in a very long time, and then I started constantly noticing that I'm actually numb every day.

Counselor: That feeling of "suddenly realizing you've been numb for a long time"—it seems more unsettling than a specific event, because you can't point to a concrete reason, yet you genuinely feel yourself changed. This past half year, besides the numbness at work, have you noticed whether this feeling has also quietly affected life outside of work?

[Turn 5]

Client: Yeah. Like before, on weekends I'd at least want to go out a bit, but now I often just sleep until noon, wake up and lie there scrolling on my phone, and before I know it the day is gone.

Counselor: This change sounds quite obvious—from being willing to go out to now being unable to

muster energy for the whole weekend. It's like that exhaustion isn't just during work hours anymore; even during time off, your body and mind are too lazy to move. In this state, how would you describe your current mood or condition?

[Turn 6]

Client: Well... if I had to describe it, probably just very empty. It's not that kind of intense sadness—more like my whole being can't lift itself up, and even on days off I don't know what to do.

Counselor: "Very empty"—that word is quite fitting. It's not a sharp pain, but rather a continuous state of having no energy, not even knowing what you want on your days off. Does this emptiness, besides work and weekends, also make you unable to muster enthusiasm for other things, like relationships or hobbies?

[Turn 7]

Client: Yes. In university I used to play in a band and play guitar, but after graduation that guitar has just been stored under my bed—I've barely taken it out since.

Counselor: That guitar stored under the bed and never taken out again—it's like the part of you that once had passion and vitality has also gradually been put away these past few years. Hearing you describe it this way, this "emptiness" seems to have spread to quite many aspects of your life, not just work. Does this state worry you?

[Turn 8]

Client: Yes, actually I'm a bit afraid I might just keep going on like this. Especially Sunday nights are the most obvious—I get anxious to the point of stomach pain, then lie there unable to sleep, my mind racing with thoughts.

Counselor: That Sunday night feeling of stomach pain, inability to sleep, mind unable to stop—it sounds really quite torturous, as if your body is sending you signals. This fear of "will I just keep going on like this," combined with physical discomfort—have you observed whether, besides Sunday nights, there are other times when you have similar anxiety reactions?

[Turn 9]

Client: Yes, quite often during meetings too. Especially those long meetings that don't really concern me much—I'll suddenly zone out thinking, will I become like my manager in ten years?

Counselor: Suddenly zoning out during meetings, having the thought "will I become like that in ten years"—this sounds not just like distraction, but more like an inner warning signal or fear about the future. It's like in your heart you're already resisting a certain "what I'll become if I keep doing this." Can you say more about that image? When you imagine becoming like your manager in ten years, what feeling emerges in your heart?

[Turn 10]

Client: Well... the first feeling is actually a bit scary. It's not that my manager is bad—it's just that I have this sense that if I really keep going, my life will probably look like that, and I surprisingly have absolutely no anticipation for that picture.

Counselor: Being able to foresee what the future will look like all the way through, yet feeling no

anticipation—this discovery is actually quite heavy. It's like you're not just tired of your current work, but you also can't muster longing for "living like this" itself. This feeling of "absolutely no anticipation"—does it also make you think that you're actually waiting for, or longing for, something different?

[Turn 11]

Client: Yeah. I actually quite envy a university classmate of mine. He later went into music—doesn't earn much, but every time I see him, I feel like his whole being, his eyes are bright.

Counselor: You mentioned his "eyes are bright"—this phrase seems to hide something you very much long for but feel you don't currently have. Behind the envy, perhaps it's not just envying him doing music, but envying that state of having light in life, having anticipation—that's also what you were like before the guitar was put away. What does this contrast mean to you?

[Turn 12]

Client: Well... yes, maybe it's more like envying that feeling of being alive. Not just getting things done every day, but truly knowing why you're doing this thing.

Counselor: "Knowing why you're doing this thing"—this phrase sounds like what you most long for now, yet also feel is most distant. The "feeling of being alive" you describe versus the current days of "getting things done"—there seems to be quite a deep gap between them. How long have you carried this gap in your heart, and have you ever tried to talk about this feeling with yourself or others?

[Turn 13]

Client: Yes, I mentioned it once to my family. During dinner I very casually said maybe I could consider changing tracks. But they just laughed and said I was overthinking. After that I didn't bring it up again.

Counselor: That casual mention being laughed off probably made you feel this feeling wasn't seriously received, so later you chose to keep it to yourself. Does that feel a bit lonely—like even wanting to seriously think about this thing, you can't find anyone to talk to?

[Turn 14]

Client: Yes, quite lonely. There's this sense that, like, even before I've figured it out myself, it's already dismissed as just random thinking, so later I just stopped talking about it.

Counselor: That feeling of being denied before you've even clarified your own thoughts—it actually makes people even more afraid to touch it, as if even you yourself have to start doubting whether this really is just "random thinking." But your willingness today to say these things layer by layer actually shows this has always been something very important and very real to you. This longing for the "feeling of being alive"—are you willing to seriously face it yourself first?

[Turn 15]

Client: Well... I think so, otherwise I wouldn't have dragged it out until now still thinking about this. But when you ask if I'm willing to face it, I get a bit stuck, because I don't really know what to do after truly facing it.

Counselor: It sounds like you're not unwilling to face it, but rather uncertain where the next step is

"after facing it." This feeling of being stuck is very reasonable, especially since you may have never had the chance to properly sort through this. Maybe there's no rush to find an answer—we can first stop here: if you truly allow yourself to seriously think about this, what do you hope to clarify first?

[Turn 16]

Client: Well... if we're not talking about some big answer, what I probably most want to clarify first is whether I truly want to change, or if I'm just too tired and annoyed right now, so I keep wanting to escape. Because these two are very different.

Counselor: This is a very good question—you're already starting to help yourself clarify. Being tired and annoyed makes people want to escape "the present moment," but if you truly want to change, it usually comes with a longing for a certain direction, a certain possibility—not just wanting to leave. You just mentioned your classmate's bright eyes, that envy—do you feel it's more like simply wanting to escape the present, or is there actually also vaguely a direction in your heart?

[Turn 17]

Client: There is, but that direction is also very vague. It's more like I have a reaction when I see things related to music, but if you really ask me whether I want to do it, I immediately retreat.

Counselor: That moment of "having a reaction but immediately retreating" is very interesting—it's like there's truly a place in your heart that's touched, but immediately another force pulls you back to where you were. Do you know what that feeling or thought is that makes you retreat?

[Turn 18]

Client: The first thought is usually, that's not realistic. Then I'd follow with thinking, I'm already 27, thinking about this now— isn't it too late?

Counselor: "That's not realistic" and "too late"—these two thoughts seem to immediately extinguish that touched part as soon as they appear. I'm very curious, whose voices do these sound like? Are they your genuine judgment, or more like some framework you've long internalized and habitually use to remind yourself?

[Turn 19]

Client: Well... more like the latter. I'm actually very familiar with that kind of talk. Back in high school I thought about pursuing music, but my dad directly said that's what rich kids play around with.

Counselor: So this phrase has been following you for so many years—"that's what rich kids play around with." It sounds like from high school it moved into your heart and became the voice that now makes you immediately retreat. I'm wondering whether this voice perhaps initially protected you, led you to choose a practical path, but now might it also be blocking you from seriously confirming what that longing in your heart actually is?

[Turn 20]

Client: Yes, I think so. Because now whenever I think in that direction, the first thing that jumps out in my mind isn't "do I want this or not," but "is this okay, would this be too stupid."

Counselor: You've noticed very clearly—that voice of "is this okay, would this be too stupid" jumps out almost automatically, getting ahead of your own "do I want this." This voice has been guarding

you for a long time, but it may also have meant you've never had a chance to truly ask yourself: setting aside practical considerations, purely as yourself, how would you answer that question?

[Turn 21]

Client: Well... I'd really just go blank on this question. It's strange—I can analyze work, analyze risks, but as soon as you ask "if it's just me myself" what I want, I suddenly don't know what to say.

Counselor: This blankness is actually very precious, because it lets you see that the ability to "just ask yourself what you want"—it probably hasn't been practiced in a very long time. It's not that you don't have an answer, but rather that voice is too used to screening things out for you first. Maybe there's no need to rush to fill this blank space right now—just knowing it's there is itself a beginning.

[Turn 22]

Client: Well, putting it that way seems right too. Because when I think about it, many of the bigger decisions in my life don't seem to have been truly decided by me.

Counselor: This is a very important discovery—you've noticed that many major decisions in your life may not have truly come from yourself. Saying this sentence also carries some weight. Can you say more? Besides changing tracks, what other bigger decisions, when you look back, would you feel "actually that wasn't chosen by me"?

[Turn 23]

Client: Like my university major—my parents filled it out for me. Later this software engineering job was also introduced by my dad. All along the way has been very smooth, but precisely because it's been too smooth, I instead have this feeling that I've just been following along.

Counselor: This phrase "too smooth, so it feels like just following along" is very profound—it's like at several important crossroads in your life, someone already paved the way for you, so you also never had a chance to practice "choosing for yourself." I'm wondering whether this might also be why this current decision particularly has you stuck—because this might be the first time in your life you truly have to practice answering "what do I want" based only on yourself, rather than having a ready-made answer to follow?

[Turn 24]

Client: Yes, I think it's a bit like that. Because before, even if I didn't like it that much, at least the path was already there. But now if I really have to choose myself, I'm actually quite panicked—like I don't know how to choose at all.

Counselor: This panic is actually very reasonable—if all along others have been paving the path first, then "choosing for yourself" is something you naturally haven't had much chance to practice. Panic doesn't mean you're incapable—it just means this is a completely new muscle. Maybe there's no rush to find an answer right now. Just seeing clearly "I've never truly practiced choosing for myself" is already a very important step. What does this panic feel like to you right now?

[Turn 25]

Client: More like the panic of having no road signs ahead. It's not simply being afraid of choosing wrong—it's like I don't even know where I want to go, and that's more scary than being arranged for.

Counselor: "Not even knowing where I want to go is more scary than being arranged for"—this phrase is very honest and also very brave. Because fearing choosing wrong still has a "wrong" to reference; but having completely no road signs means you have to start from zero practicing listening to your own voice, and that indeed can make people feel dizzy and without support. Maybe right now there's no need to rush to find a direction—just first let yourself stand in this blank space and feel what "not knowing" itself tastes like. Do you think you can do that?

[Turn 26]

Client: I guess so. Honestly, usually as soon as I feel this kind of "not knowing," I immediately want to shut it off. But the way you put it, maybe I can first not rush to force myself to have an answer.

Counselor: This is a very difficult practice, because your habit all along has been to encounter "not knowing" and try to fill it or shut it off. Now being willing to let yourself stay in the blankness a bit longer is actually already very different. This space of allowing yourself to "temporarily not know"—that itself is practicing trusting yourself, not needing to have an answer right away. Having talked to this point today, what does your heart feel like right now?

[Turn 27]

Client: Well... a bit more relaxed, I guess. At least now it's not that feeling of constantly forcing myself to make a decision immediately. Instead it's more like, first admitting I truly don't know—that seems to be okay too.

Counselor: This feeling of being "a bit more relaxed" is very precious. It means today you were willing to first put down the pressure of urgently needing an answer and let yourself honestly stay in "not knowing." This is actually a very difficult step, especially for you who's been used to analyzing things clearly and making decisions all along. Let's stop here for today. Would you be willing to take this feeling of "first admitting not knowing is also okay" back with you and try to pay more attention in your life to those moments that make you "have a reaction"?

[Turn 28]

Client: Yeah, I can do that. I think this is much better than constantly forcing myself to think clearly about reality. At least first see what I actually have feelings about. We can end here for today.

Counselor: Okay, let's end here for today then. Looking back over this whole conversation, you started from struggling with "should I quit or not," and gradually saw that behind this is actually "I've never truly practiced choosing for myself." You also discovered that those thoughts of "not realistic, too late" are actually others' voices and not yours. These are very deep insights. I'm very curious—having talked like this today, what parts were helpful to you? Are there any places you felt weren't that useful, or where you'd hope I could respond in a different way?

[Turn 29]

Client: What was helpful should be that you didn't keep asking me to choose an answer right now. It was more like first helping me distinguish that what I'm stuck on isn't just the quitting issue—it's also that I really don't know how to ask myself what I want.

Counselor: Thank you for such honest feedback—this is also very important to me. During this time

today, you went from the surface-level question of "should I quit or not" all the way to seeing that deeper, more core task—learning to ask yourself "what do I want." This is very difficult self-awareness and also requires great courage to be willing to touch. This insight—how would you describe its significance to you?

[Turn 30]

Client: Well... it's more like, before I always treated this as just "do I want to change jobs or not," but today I kind of discovered that what I truly don't know how to do is make decisions for myself. Seeing this first makes quite a difference to me.

Counselor: From "should I change jobs or not" to seeing "I don't really know how to make decisions for myself"—this is indeed a very different level. You've very seriously accompanied yourself to this point today. The road ahead probably can't be accomplished through today's one conversation, but rather needs to slowly accumulate in life the practice of "listening to yourself." I'm wondering, after you go back, besides paying attention to those moments that make you have reactions, is there anyone around you who you feel you could talk to about these things more comfortably, without being laughed off?

[Turn 31]

Client: There doesn't seem to be anyone at the moment. This is also why I haven't really talked about it before—because thinking it through, I'd feel like if I said it, it would probably just be dismissed as me being too tired from work lately.

Counselor: It sounds like currently there isn't anyone a Turn you can talk to about these things comfortably, which also means this feeling has only been carried by you alone, without a chance to be properly received. Besides today's conversation, [would you consider that going forward you could also continue through counseling like this to have a space where you can practice speaking out and listening to yourself?](#)

[Turn 32]

Client: Yeah, I would. I think this kind of space makes quite a difference for me. At least today is one of the few times I've talked about these things without it being dismissed as just complaining about work.

Counselor: Hearing that this was a rare experience of being properly received for you—I also very much treasure today's conversation. [Besides the counseling space, that guitar stored under your bed—might it also be a way for you to practice "listening to yourself"? It doesn't have to be any major decision—maybe just occasionally taking it out to play a bit, seeing if that familiar feeling is still there.](#)

[Turn 33]

Client: Well... I've thought about that. [But even just taking it out feels a bit strange to me now—like I don't know what mood to be in when touching it. But maybe I can try it first.](#)

Counselor: "Try it first"—that phrase is very good. You don't need to immediately have some particular mood. Allowing yourself to touch it with a sense of strangeness is also a kind of practice. Today, accompanying you from "should I quit or not" all the way to seeing that you don't really know how to

make decisions for yourself—this journey wasn't easy. Thank you also for being willing to share these things with me so honestly. I wish you well in gradually practicing listening to your own voice going forward. This door is always here—if you want to come back and talk again later, you're always welcome. Goodbye.